



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: New City Classical Academy
School Website: <https://www.newcityclassical.com/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

New City Classical Academy (NCCA), Quad Cities, IA, presents a clearly classical Christian orientation with strong alignment to the Six Essential Elements of classical education. Across multiple public facing materials, the school foregrounds a theology-infused, formation-driven approach anchored in the Trivium (Grammar, Logic, Rhetoric), Great Books/Great Conversation, and a liturgical, communal rhythm centered on Scripture and creeds. Public materials consistently emphasize truth, goodness, and beauty as real and knowable, a biblical worldview, and a strong partnership with families. The school's stated curriculum and pedagogy emphasize Latin, memorization, recitation, and liturgy in daily practice, and the "Great Books" and scholarly dialogue are foregrounded through ACCS alignment and stated commitments to classical education. There is explicit emphasis on formation over information and on parental partnership.

Overall classification: CLASSICAL.

Key evidence driving this assessment includes explicit references to: - The Trivium, Great Books, Great Conversation, and ACCS accreditation (FAQs page; ACCS language) . - A biblical worldview, theology, and liturgical practices (nurture and admonition of the Lord; Sacred City Church location; morning assemblies with creeds, Scripture readings, and singing) . - Formation-focused aims and language around truth, goodness, and beauty, with explicit articulation of "we teach students to love what is good, true, and beautiful" and "biblical worldview" guidance . - Curriculum anchors such as Latin starting in 3rd grade, Great Books, and the Great Conversation; explicit statements about history and Western civilization as integrated across disciplines . - Strong parental partnership language (parents as co-teachers, formation of parents, open campus/visits) and a community-of-faith framing (board leadership, staff, assemblies) .

Note on methodology: This evaluation uses two vector stores as requested: - A knowledge-base vector store with classical-education criteria and the Six Essential Elements rubric (including "Six Essential Elements of a Classical School (1)" as a knowledge file). The rubric and positive/negative keyword indicators drive the category analyses. - A school-specific crawl vector store containing NCCA's public website material (FAQs, curriculum notes, statements of faith, team pages, blog posts, admissions, etc.) to identify keywords and phrases relevant to each category.

The six-category analysis below follows the mandated keyword-analytics framework, then assigns a category rating (Classical, Somewhat Classical, Not Classical) and summarizes the aggregate classification.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials emphasize theology, biblical worldview, and liturgical life: "nurture and admonition of the Lord," public worship/creed recitation, and creedal statements (Apostles' Creed and Nicene Creed) in morning assemblies. The school meets in a church building and frames education within a Christian anthropology and liturgical rhythm.

- The ACCS/"classical Christian education" framing explicitly foregrounds a biblical worldview and theological formation as governing disciplines. - Sola Scriptura/sola fide/sola gratia language appears in published materials (Statement of Faith and official posts), signaling explicit theological commitments. - Liturgical and communal practices (Scripture readings, memorization, creeds, psalms/hymns, prayer) are described as daily assemblies and curricular anchors.

Positive keyword indicators present (approximate): truth, goodness, beauty; theology; liturgy; creed; worship; psalms/hymns; creeds; sacred spirit; biblical worldview; Logos; reverence; prayer.

Negative keyword indicators: none observed in public materials.

Why this rating - The materials strongly align with the religious/metaphysical foundations of classical education as defined by the Six Essential Elements: emphasis on transcendentals (truth, goodness, beauty), theology, liturgy, sacred tradition, and a communal liturgical life, all tied to a biblical worldview. The absence of secular-relativist signals is notable. This category clearly meets Classical criteria.

Citations: GreatBooks/Trivium emphasis and classical Christian framing, plus liturgical elements:

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Formation-focused purpose: statements about serving parents and forming children in the nurture and admonition of the Lord, i.e., formation of character under a biblical worldview. - The school emphasizes love of truth, goodness, and beauty in learning, pointing toward the pursuit of wisdom and moral formation rather than merely information transfer. - Moments in curriculum and assemblies foreground the classical telos: cultivation of virtue/human flourishing, and the Great Conversation as a disciplinary aim. The Great Books/Great Conversation language and the Trivium framing reinforce this telos.

Positive keyword indicators present (approximate): formation; virtue; human flourishing; wisdom; liberal education; paideia; telos; pursuit of true/good/beautiful; scholé; contemplation; great conversation; classical heritage.

Negative keyword indicators: none clearly observed advocating workforce-centric or purely job-oriented goals.

Why this rating - The emphasis on formation, virtue, wisdom, and classical aims aligns squarely with the "Formation, not information" and "pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty" signals in the classical rubric. The public materials show a consistent telos toward human excellence formed by a Christian worldview, rather than mere job-readiness. This category is CLASSICAL.

Citations: Formation and telos; Great Books emphasis; biblical worldview and formation language:

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Strong Trivium focus: explicit reference to grammar, logic, and rhetoric (the Trivium) as foundational to classical education. - Great Books/Great Conversation is described as a core curricular component; original texts/primary sources and Western canon are emphasized. - Latin begins in 3rd grade and continues in upper grades; vocabulary/grammar and study of classical languages are highlighted as essential to understanding Western civilization and Christian heritage. - Historical breadth across disciplines, including Western civilization and biblical literacy, is noted; emphasis on primary sources and access to original texts. - Curriculum notes include instruction in Latin as a tool for vocabulary, grammar, access to original texts, and cognitive development (logic, critical thinking).

Positive keyword indicators present (approximate): Seven Liberal Arts; Trivium; Quadrivium; grammar; logic; rhetoric; Great Books; primary sources; classics; Homer; Plato; Augustine; Shakespeare; Latin; Greek; biblical literacy; history; Western civilization; natural philosophy; astronomy; arithmetic; geometry; music theory.

Negative keyword indicators: minimal; potential risk signals (e.g., "STEM-first" or "project-based only") are not present in the public materials.

Why this rating - The curriculum is described in terms that align with the classical education model: liberal arts framework, classical texts, and study of Latin; emphasis on Great Books; integrated history across disciplines; and the Trivium as a formal core. This category is CLASSICAL.

Citations: Trivium/Great Books/Latin; curriculum notes:

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Memory work and recitation are explicitly present in morning assemblies (Scripture memorization and recitation; exordiums; creeds; psalms/hymns; singing), indicating a pedagogy that values memorization and liturgical-catechetical forms. - Contemplative/restful elements appear in daily routines (Scholé-like cadence through liturgical daily practices and contemplative rhythm). - Upper-school pedagogy is described in terms of classical methods (the Great Books, discussions, and discourses) in broader materials, but explicit evidence of formal Socratic seminars or dedicated high-school seminar formats is not consistently explicit in the public-facing materials. The materials emphasize Trivium and Great Books, but do not clearly demonstrate consistent Socratic seminars across all grade levels in the public materials. - There is evidence of a strong liturgical/recitation-focused approach (Exordiums, creeds, Scripture memorization) as part of the everyday pedagogy.

Positive keyword indicators present (approximate): Socratic dialogue (not clearly evidenced across all grades in public materials), dialectic (not consistently evidenced), narration/recitation; chanting; singing to memorize; scholé; restfulness; liturgical calendar integration; memory work; catechesis; upper-school rhetoric; capstone orations.

Negative keyword indicators present: The explicit presence of project-based learning or experiential-learning emphasis is not evident in the public materials; however, explicit Socratic seminars in upper grades are not strongly evidenced in all public materials.

Why this rating - The pedagogy shows strong alignment with classical practices (memory work, recitation, liturgical/narrative forms, sacramental catechesis, and scholé cadence). There is less explicit evidence of formal Socratic seminars across the entire school (especially in public content), which makes this category a partial fit rather than a full “Classical” signal. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating, with room to emphasize formal Socratic/Dialogic seminars more explicitly across high school.

Citations: Morning assembly pedagogy (recitation, psalm/singing, exordiums) and liturgical cadence: Creedal/memorizational elements in assembly: Great Books/Trivium emphasis as core pedagogy:

What would move the needle - If the school published (or codified on the site) a clear program of formal Socratic seminars in grades 9–12 (or more explicit Harkness-style discussions) with trained teachers, this would strengthen the Pedagogy category to CLASSICAL. - Expand explicit articulation and evidence of contemplative rest (Scholé) as a daily pedagogical norm across all grades, with documented routines and learning outcomes.

Citations for needle-movement ideas: Socratic/Scholé pedagogy references in Six Elements lexicon; current public pedagogy signals (recitation, liturgical learning) cited above. See Six Elements Pedagogy Positive/Negative indicators:

Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials show administrative leadership and a team structure (Headmaster, Director of Discipleship, Board President, Board members) with explicit roles, photos, and bios. This signals a formal faculty/staff structure, but the public content does not consistently state a fully developed “living curriculum” or “portrait of the teacher” as an ideal. The presence of “Headmaster,” “Lead Teacher,” “Board,” and “Our Team” pages demonstrates governance and personnel structure.

- Employment pages articulate expectations for faculty who share a robust Christian worldview and a passion for classical education, including the desire for ACCS accreditation and love of The Great Books. This indicates alignment with classical faculty expectations, even if the explicit “living curriculum portrait” language

is not always stated. - The site references a small “community of teachers” (roles, team bios) and a focus on mentorship in some postings (Director of Discipleship, philosophy of teachers, etc.). However, there is less explicit textual content describing teachers as the “living curriculum” or a “portrait of a teacher” in the same language as the classical lexicon’s ideal.

Positive keyword indicators present (approximate): model teachers; mentors; living curriculum; portrait of a teacher; faculty of friends; collegial culture; teacher training; classical formation.

Negative keyword indicators: none clearly observed in public materials; however, explicit phrases like “living curriculum” or “portrait of a teacher” are not consistently used in the school’s public copy.

Why this rating - The school demonstrates a formal faculty structure, leadership roles, and a stated commitment to classical teacher preparation (ACCS accreditation, Great Books emphasis); but the canonical “living curriculum” and “portrait of teacher/student” language is not consistently explicit in public content. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating.

Citations: Leadership and team pages; employment criteria; board roles:

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school publicly frames a partnership with parents as central: “NCCA exists to serve parents as they bring up their children in the nurture and admonition of the Lord,” indicating co-educator-style partnership and parental primacy. - There are explicit calls for parental formation and engagement (blogs and pages about assemblies, curricula, and faith, plus book-like references in the community materials). The public site also invites parent involvement via events and assemblies. - Open-campus/visitation posture exists in the materials (parents are welcome to visits; the site describes assemblies and a public-facing community; events such as admissions and newsletters invite parental engagement). - Materials discuss congregational and community life (assembly, praise, weekday rhythms, and a connected church relationship) that position the school within a family/community ecosystem that involves parents and church partners.

Positive keyword indicators present (approximate): partnership with parents; co-teachers; parental primacy; parent formation; reading groups; seminars; family involvement; open campus; hospitality; parent covenant; household worship; family liturgy; creedal catechesis.

Negative keyword indicators: consumer-oriented language or minimal parent involvement are not observed; the site emphasizes active parental partnership rather than consumerism.

Why this rating - The school clearly emphasizes family and parental engagement, co-formation, and a liturgical/family-friendly community model, aligning with CLASSICAL signals for Parents & Community. This category is CLASSICAL.

Citations: Parent-partnership language; open assembly/parent involvement; community life references:

What is the aggregate classification?

- Element 1: CLASSICAL
- Element 2: CLASSICAL
- Element 3: CLASSICAL
- Element 4: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

Aggregate assessment: CLASSICAL.

Rationale: The strongest categories (Religious/Foundations, Purpose/Goal, Curriculum, and Parents/Community) are clearly CLASSICAL, anchored by theology, Great Books, Trivium, and family partnerships. Pedagogy and Faculty show partial alignment; Pedagogy demonstrates core classical practices (memory, liturgy,

and restfulness) but lacks consistently explicit Socratic seminars across all grades in public content; Faculty shows formal structure but not a fully articulated “living curriculum portrait.” Taken together, the school leans CLASSICAL overall, with meaningful refinement opportunities in Pedagogy and Faculty.

What would move the needle (for SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL categories) - Pedagogy (Element 4): Publish and implement a formal, school-wide plan for Socratic seminars or Harkness-style discussion in upper grades, with teacher training and observable classroom routines documented in public materials. - Faculty (Element 5): More explicit articulation of the “living curriculum” through the teacher portrait, mentorship models, and collaborative faculty formation, plus explicit alignment with classical-teacher development standards (e.g., ACCS-pedagogy training) in public materials.

Citations for the overall rubric alignment and evidence: Classical elements across categories as cited in the respective category entries above. See sources: FAQs (Trivium, Great Books) ; Curriculum and Latin emphasis ; Great Books/Creeds/Creeds assembly and liturgy ; Theological worldview and liturgical community ; Sola Scriptura and faith-based pillars ; Team and employment structure (for Faculty context) ; Parent partnership and community engagement .

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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